to ensure plenty of close-ups of Modi and crowd shots that would effectively project the vastness of the rally.

There was even a small research team at the BJP party headquarters which would monitor all the media to check on what the Opposition was saying about Modi and ensure that their leader could respond quickly if required. ‘We created a system of instant feedback, apart from providing all the background of a constituency Modi was visiting,’ says Naqvi. The information would then be sent to the chief minister’s office where it was filtered by Prateek Doshi, an OSD to the chief minister, who had originally joined the Modi secretariat as an intern on a fellowship programme. As with so many members of Team Modi, Prateek was young, bright and professional (he had done a management degree from Singapore).

But the real heavy lifting was done by Modi himself. Starting his day at 5 a.m., he would go to bed well past by midnight. Meditation, a light breakfast, a pre-fixed interview. By 8.30 a.m. (sometimes even earlier, if he was flying to the north-east), Modi would be ready to take off. Travelling with him was his ever-faithful personal assistant, O.P. Singh, while two others, Dinesh Thakur and Tanmay Mehta, would hold the fort at the chief minister’s office. All three had been drawn through the RSS pool.

As he criss-crossed the country giving one speech after another, he would drink warm water to protect his throat. He kept his food simple—dal, roti and *sabzi* that the local rally organizers would prepare. ‘We only told them to put less oil and salt, and keep it very basic,’ a Modi aide told me. On long flights, he would catch a little sleep but mostly worked on his speeches and Gujarat government files. He would almost always come back to Gandhinagar every night, primarily because he didn’t want to bear the additional parking costs of the private plane hired from the Adanis, he said.

He was inexhaustible. ‘Earlier, the aim was to just target winning areas, but by the end, almost every candidate wanted Modiji to address at least one rally in their area,’ Naqvi told me later. North, central and western India had been the BJP’s primary catchment area for Mission 272-plus, and this is where Modi’s original travel plan had been focused. But carried away by the large crowds, Team Modi was now seeing the possibility of extra seats